

Westhampton Solar/Energy Subcommittee
Meeting Minutes
Thursday, June 20, 2024

Called to Order at 5:42pm with Susan Bronstein, Scott Stanton, Jennifer Milikowsky, and Teri Anderson present.

Reviewed and discussed strategies and next steps based on information in these documents:

- a. Eversource grid capacity email
- b. Westhampton Elementary School Ground Mount System Design
- c. UMass Solar Assessment and Action Plan reports

Next Steps:

1. Highest priority is moving forward with Town Hall and Public Safety Building solar projects.
 - a. Discuss with Northeast Solar the possibility of extending the contract with them to contact Eversource on Town's behalf to discuss Town Hall and Public Safety Building solar roof arrays and file necessary paperwork to obtain Eversource connection approval. Teri will discuss with Doug and arrange a phone consultation with Northeast Solar to discuss. We are taking this approach because Phil Dowling's Eversource contact told him that the Town needed to have a consultant contact them about any proposed solar grid connections (as per telephone conversation Phil had with Teri).
 - b. This will give us more information on if Eversource grid capacity will accommodate our most immediate needs and determine if these projects can proceed as planned.
2. After we obtain approvals for Town Hall and Public Safety, create comprehensive plan to determine feasibility of other solar arrays at Elementary School, landfill, and possibly high school.
 - a. Engage Northeast Solar or another consultant to assist Town to:
 - i. Determine best design options at Elementary School, landfill, and possibly high school - determine roof mounted, ground mounted, or parking lot canopy best options, and what to do with potential excess solar capacity beyond municipal solar needs.
 - ii. Also, does the grid capacity affect private solar arrays of any size in town? The UMass solar study indicated that arrays of <50mw could be accommodated, but the status may have changed since that analysis was completed.
 - iii. Determine what is necessary to extend 3-phase power to the sites if needed to accommodate larger systems.

Question: Will the 10% design and contingency costs included in Town Meeting budget approvals cover the consultant costs? If not, we might need to wait to apply and include this analysis in an MVP grant application, but it would be stronger application to do this upfront feasibility analysis first.

3. Create a list of work tasks/research/permits needed to proceed with an MVP grant application to be submitted in FY26 funding round next winter.
 - a. Consult other communities that have completed landfill solar projects to determine best approach.
4. If grid is at capacity and no new solar arrays can be approved in Westhampton, follow up with Ann Gobi's office to obtain state assistance. Are there state incentives or funding for grid capacity expansion? If no, is the cost of grid capacity improvement an allowable expense under the MVP grant program?
5. Review bidding laws to determine if public construction or Ch. 25 Energy Projects is best procedure to follow.

Next meeting date: Thursday, August 1, 5:30pm

Adjourned at 6:40pm

Minutes submitted by Teri Anderson